

PM'S VISIT: Taking bilateral relations to the next level

Prime Minister Manmohan Singh embarks on a 3-day visit to Japan from October 21, 2008. The PM's visit assumes great significance as the two countries have taken special initiatives over the past few years to give a new dimension to bilateral relations, with specific focus on economic partnership.

Prime Minister Singh is expected to hold intensive talks with his counterpart, Mr. Taro Aso on a wide range of subjects, including the economic challenges facing the world today. The PM, accompanied by his wife Gursharan Kaur, will also be received in audience by the Emperor and Empress of Japan.

Japan's Ambassador to India, Mr. Hideaki Domichi, said both Prime Ministers have known with each other very well, and "this is the opportune time for them to consolidate and elevate our bilateral relationship to a new height in line with the "Roadmap for New Dimensions to the Strategic and Global Partnership" that has been initiated and committed during the mutual visits of the Prime Ministers in the past few years."

Prime Minister Singh and Prime Minister Aso are also expected to exchange views on tackling the international financial crisis and the global economic situation.

Japan and India may take some major decisions on economic co-operations between the two countries in infrastructure projects in India during Prime Minister Singh's visit. Besides the Economic Partnership Agreement (EPA) which is under negotiations at present, the two countries are expected to discuss some major infrastructure projects in India, including the Dedicated Freight Corridor project and the Delhi-Mumbai Industrial Corridor project.

India has emerged as the single largest recipient of ODA (overseas development assistance) loans from Japan for the last five years. This year too, India will be the single largest recipient of ODA from Japan.

At a recent seminar in New Delhi, Mr. Domichi, said Japan is one of the largest partners for India's economic development and will continue to be so.

The then Japanese Prime Minister, Mr. Yoshiro Mori's visit to India in 2000 paved a fresh path for bringing the two countries together. Bilateral visits by Prime Ministers and Cabinet Ministers of both the countries have increased significantly since then.